Lesson 28

Temptation

"But when you are tempted, he will also
provide a way out so that you can
stand up under it."
(1 Corinthians 10:13)

Temptation: an enticement or solicitation to sin

The devil is the original source of temptation in our world. From the time he first tempted Adam and Eve to eat of the forbidden fruit, he has been working to draw men into sin. Fortunately for mankind, God sent his son, Jesus Christ, to save humanity from sin and to defeat the work of the devil. If we turn to God for help and follow the advice given in the Bible, we can resist temptation and keep from sinning.

Synopsis

The following is the story of how temptation entered into the world and how it will ultimately be defeated.

Lucifer (later renamed "devil" and "Satan") was a powerful angel who was banished from heaven because he desired to be equal to God. After falling out of favor with God, he came to earth and appears in the story of Adam and Eve. Satan took the form of a serpent (Rev.12:9) and tempted Eve to eat of the forbidden fruit (that gave knowledge of good and evil). He deceived her and told her that if she ate the fruit she would be like God.

Eve ate of the forbidden fruit, and then gave it to Adam to eat. When God saw what they had done, he was angered by their actions and expelled them from the Garden of Eden. Because of "Adam's fall" (that is, his disobedience), all human beings have inherited a sinful nature.

During the years following the lives of Adam and Eve, the world fell deeper and deeper into sin because of the work of Satan on

earth. In response to the ever increasing sin, God sent His only son, Jesus Christ, to save mankind from sin and defeat the work of the evil one (ie, the devil).[1]

When fulfilling this mission, Christ Himself was tempted by the devil,[2] but He did not give in to sin. Following His temptation in the wilderness, Jesus experienced first-hand just how potentially powerful Satan could be.[3] As a result, He prayed to God that His Heavenly Father would protect His disciples from the influence of the devil.[4] In a similar fashion, when He taught His followers how to pray (the famous "Lord's Prayer"), He taught them to pray to God to deliver them from temptation and from the evil one.[5]

As we consider the work of the devil, remember that his main objective is to tempt human beings to sin and disobey God. In order to achieve this objective, the devil is incredibly "tricky" and resourceful. He is a liar[6] and a murderer[7] and he never tells the truth.[7] He is a master of deception, and he pretends to be good

The reason the Son of God appeared
was to destroy the devil's work.
(1 John 3:8)[1]

Then Jesus was led by the Spirit into the desert
to be tempted by the devil.
(Matthew 4:1)[2]

For we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses, but we have one who has been tempted in every way, just as we are—yet was without sin.
(Hebrews 5:15)[3]

My prayer is not that you take them out of the world
but that you protect them from the evil one.
(John 17:15)[4]

And lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from the evil one.
(Matthew 6:13)[5]

When he lies, he speaks his native language,
for he is a liar and the father of lies.
(John 8:44)[6]

He was a murderer from the beginning, not holding to the truth,
for there is no truth in him.
(John 8:44)[7]

when in fact he is not.[8] He is aware of our weaknesses, and he is always lurking in the background of our lives, scheming and plotting and waiting for a chance to entice us into sin.[9]

Even more disturbing, the Bible tells us that Satan does not work alone.[10] Other evil spirits also do his work.** But despite the relentless efforts of Satan and his followers, it is important to understand that, when all is said and done, God wins!

Although the non-Christian world is hopelessly under the control of Satan, Christians are not alone in their struggles.[11] Satan is not more powerful than the Holy Spirit who dwells within each and every Christian.[12] And Satan cannot bring eternal harm to God's children. The Lord strengthens and protects us from the devil[13] and limits his power over us.

Satan himself masquerades as an angel of light.
(2 Corinthians 11:14)[8]

Your enemy the devil prowls around like a roaring lion
looking for someone to devour.
(1 Peter 5:8)[9]

Dear friends, do not believe every spirit, but test the spirits
to see whether they are from God.
(1 John 4:1)[10]

We know that we are children of God, and that the whole world
Is under the control of the evil one.
(1 John 5:19)[11]

The one who is in you [the Holy Spirit] is greater
than the one who is in the world.
(1 John 4:4)[12]

But the Lord is faithful, and he will strengthen and protect you
from the evil one.
(2 Thessalonians 3:3)[13]

**For example, evil spirits sometimes attempt to deceive God's people by leading them to think that the Holy Spirit is inspiring the message given by a teacher or preacher when in fact the it is being inspired by the lying spirit of the devil. The way to discern the difference is to test whether the spirit acknowledges Jesus Christ as the Son of God. (1 John 4:22-3)

Although all human beings are tempted by the devil to do evil, God will never let you be tempted beyond what you can bear,[14] and He will always provide a way out so that you can achieve victory over the temptation.[15,16]

Therefore, you should never blame God if you "give in" to temptation and sin. In the face of temptation, you have a choice. The final decision to sin or not to sin is your own.

And you should not blame God for the fact that you are being tempted in the first place. God Himself does not tempt human beings.[17] It is the work of the devil and our own evil desires that lead us into temptation.[17]

In the end, when Christ once again returns to earth, the devil will finally be silenced. There will be a day when he is no longer able to tempt us to sin. God will eventually crush Satan[18] and drive him out of this world.[19] He will be judged by God and thrown into hell, where he will be tortured day and night for ever and ever.[20]

And God is faithful; he will not let you be tempted beyond what you can bear.
(1 Corinthians 10:13)[14]

But when you are tempted, he will also provide a way out so that you can stand up under it.
(1 Corinthians 10:13)[15]

The Lord knows how to rescue godly men from trials.
(2 Peter 2:9)[16]

When tempted, no one should say, "God is tempting me." For God cannot be tempted by evil, nor does he tempt anyone; but each one is tempted when, by his own evil desire, he is dragged away and enticed.
(James 1:13-14)[17]

The God of peace will soon crush Satan under your feet.
(Romans 16:20)[18]

Now is the time for judgment on this world; now the prince of this world will be driven out. **(John 12:31)[19]**

And the devil, who deceived them, was thrown into the lake of burning sulfur, where the beast and the false prophet had been thrown. They will be tormented day and night for ever and ever.
(Revelation 20:10)[20]

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God's Guidance

How can temptation be overcome?

Stay Alert and Keep Your Guard Up: One of the best ways to protect yourself from temptation is to stay alert and keep your guard up.[21-23] You may think that your are spiritually strong and able to withstand temptation, but remember that the flesh is weak.[21]

If you have an area of sin in your life where you are particularly vulnerable to sin, you should be vigilant and pay special attention to that area so that the temptation does not "sneak through" your defenses and lead you to sin.

Test everything that comes into your senses and determine whether it is of God or of the evil one. Hold on to what is good, and avoid that which is evil.[24]

Avoid "Dangerous" Situations: Learn to avoid situations that are likely to lead to the temptation to sin. For example, if you are married, don't deprive each other of normal sexual relations, or you will expose yourself to the obvious temptation of Satan.[25]

Watch and pray so that you will not fall into temptation.
The spirit is willing, but the body is weak.
(Matthew 25:26)[21]

Be self-controlled and alert.
(1 Peter 5:8)[22]

In the paths of the wicked lie thorns and snares,
but he who guards his soul stays far from them.
(Proverbs 22:5)[23]

Test everything. Hold on to the good. Avoid every kind of evil.
(1 Thessalonians 5:21-22)[24]

Do not deprive each other except by mutual consent and
for a time, so that you may devote yourselves to prayer.
Then come together again so that Satan will not tempt
you because of your lack of self-control.
(1 Corinthians 7:5)[25]

Don't let the sun go down while you are still angry, or you might give the devil a foothold, which will result in sin.[26] And don't run around trying to get rich, for such people often fall into temptation and a trap, which ultimately plunges them into ruin and destruction.[27]

Put on the Armor of God: One of the most important things you can do to resist temptation[28] is to put on the "full armor of God" so that you can defend yourself against the devil's schemes.[29] To understand this analogy, think of a Roman soldier ready for battle. Each part of the uniform represents a part of the spiritual armor that you should be wearing in order to protect yourself from the evil one.

The **belt** of the uniform represents "truth."[30] When battling the devil, it always important to focus on the truth,[31] since we have already seen that the evil one "lies and deceives." Jesus Christ

Do not let the sun go down while you are still angry,
and do not give the devil a foothold.
(Ephesians 4:26-27)26

People who want to get rich fall into temptation and a trap
and into many foolish and harmful desires that plunge
men into ruin and destruction.
(1 Timothy 6:9)27

Resist the devil, and he will flee from you.
(James 4:7)28

Put on the full armor of God so that you can take your stand
against the devil's schemes.
(Ephesians 6:11)29

Stand firm then, with the belt of truth buckled around
your waist, with the breastplate of righteousness in place,
and with your feet fitted with the readiness that comes
from the gospel of peace.
(Ephesians 6:14-15)30

Surely you desire truth in the inner parts;
you teach me wisdom in the inmost place.
(Psalm 51:6)31

proclaimed that He was the "way and the truth and the life."[32] If we follow Christ's teachings, then we will know the truth and the truth will set us free from the influence of the devil.[33]

We can also find truth by becoming sensitive to the Holy Spirit, who is sometimes called the "Spirit of truth."[34] When we first accept Christ as our Lord and Savior, the Holy Spirit comes to reside in us. This is how we know that we are children of God.[35] The Holy Spirit is the great Counselor who was sent by God to guide us into all truth.[36] We need to listen to the Holy Spirit and not "grieve the Holy Spirit" by sinning and falling prey to the temptation of the evil one.[37]

The **breastplate** of the uniform represents "righteousness." The more righteous and holy you are, the better prepared you will be to resist the temptation of the evil one. You are to conduct yourself in a manner that is worthy of the gospel of Christ.[38] At the end of

I am the way and the truth and the life. No one comes
to the Father except through me.
(John 14:6)[32]

If you hold to my teaching, you are really my disciples.
Then you will know the truth, and the truth will set you free.
(John 8:31-32)[33]

But when he, the Spirit of truth, comes,
he will guide you into all truth.
(John 16:13)[34]

And this is how we know that he lives in us:
We know it by the Spirit he gave us.
(1 John 3:24)[35]

When the Counselor comes, whom I will send to you from
the Father, the Spirit of truth who goes out from the Father,
he will testify about me.
(John 15:26)[36]

And do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God, with whom you were
sealed for the day of redemption.
(Ephesians 4:30)[37]

Whatever happens, conduct yourselves in a manner
worthy of the gospel of Christ.
(Philippians 1:27)[38]

the day, if you stay the course, your righteousness will "shine like the sun in the kingdom of God."[39]

The **shoes** the soldier is wearing represents your readiness to spread the "gospel of peace."[40] The more willing and ready you are to go out into the world and preach the gospel of Christ,[40] the more peace you will have within yourself,[41] and the better prepared you will be to resist the devil.

The **shield** the soldier uses represents "faith."[42] Take time to develop your faith and belief in Jesus Christ, so that the strength of your faith will stand fast against the attack of the evil one.[43-45]

The **helmet** of the uniform represents "salvation."[46] Remember the price that Christ paid on the cross (when He suffered an agonizing

Then the righteous will shine like the sun in the kingdom of their Father. He who has ears, let him hear.
(Matthew 13:43)[39]

He came and preached peace to you who were far away and peace to those who were near.
(Ephesians 2:17)[40]

I have told you these things, so that in me you may have peace.
(John 16:33)[41]

In addition to all this, take up the shield of faith, with which you can extinguish all the flaming arrows of the evil one.
(Ephesians 6:16)[42]

Now faith is being sure of what we hope for and certain of what we do not see.
(Hebrews 11:1)[43]

Build yourselves up in your most holy faith and pray in the Holy Spirit.
(Jude 1:20)[44]

Fight the good fight of the faith.
(1 Timothy 6:12)[45]

Take the helmet of salvation and the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God.
(Ephesians 6:17)[46]

death and died for your sins)[47,48] so that you could live with him forever in heaven. The devil may try to trick you into thinking that you aren't saved, or that the sin he is trying to get you to engage in "isn't that important." Remember that our Savior does not want you to sin, and that he suffered and died for each and every sin you choose to commit.[49,50]

Finally, the **sword** of the uniform represents the "word of God." One of the best defenses against the devil's temptation is for you to hide the word of God in your heart so that you do not sin against the Lord.[51,52] Every word of God is perfect[53] and flawless[54] and it will stand forever.[55] Do not neglect God's word,[56] for it will make you wiser than all your enemies, including the devil.[57]

You were bought at a price; do not become slaves of men.
(1 Corinthians 7:23)[47]

At just the right time, when were still powerless,
Christ died for the ungodly.
(Romans 5:6)[48]

He was delivered over to death for our sins
and was raised to life for our justification.
(Romans 4:25)[49]

This is love: not that we loved God, but that he loved us
and sent his Son as an atoning sacrifice for our sins.
(1 John 4:10)[50]

I have hidden your word in my heart
that I might not sin against you.
(Psalm 119:11)[51]

When your words came, I ate them; they were my joy and my heart's delight, for I bear your name, O LORD God Almighty.
(Jeremiah 15:16)[52]

The law of the LORD is perfect, reviving the soul.
(Psalm 19:7)[53]

Every word of God is flawless.
(Proverbs 30:5)[54]

The grass withers and the flowers fall,
but the word of our God stands forever.
(Isaiah 40:8)[55]

Prayer: We have already discussed the importance of prayer in overcoming temptation. By way of review, remember that when you are confronted with temptation, if you turn to God, he will always give you a "way out,"[15,16] and God will never let you be tempted beyond what you can bear.[14]

Humbly submit ***your will*** to ***God's will***, and pray for his strength and guidance. You may not be able to fight the temptation on your own, but it is certainly not too big for God.

I will not neglect your word.
(Psalm 119:16)[56]

Your commands make me wiser than my enemies,
for they are ever with me.
(Psalm 119:98)[57]